



There was a time when
the idea of freedom was a
backroom thriller in which
Gandhi, Nehru, Patel,
and Jinnah were the
main protagonists.

hero of (Hindus) is a foe of the (Muslims)... To yoke together two such nations under a single State, one as a numerical minority and the other as a majority, must lead to growing discontent and the final destruction of any fabric that may be built up for the government of such a state." The impeccable, cigar-chomping constitutionalist was no longer the so-called ambassador of Hindu-Muslim unity; he was a Muslim separatist. As the founder of Pakistan, though, he spoke another language: "You are free; you are free to go to your temples, you are free to go to your mosques or to any other place or worship in this state of Pakistan. You may belong to any religion or caste or creed, that has nothing to do with the business of the state." So who's the real Jinnah—the separatist or the secularist? Or was his separatism a tactic in his solo fight against the combined might of Nehru and Patel?

History provides no definitive answers, for historians are not necessarily the finest interpreters of human impulses. After all, how did the two westernised constitutionalists become the principal antagonists? Was it a clash of egos as well? In the words of the "impetuous Pandit", Jinnah "felt completely out of his element in the khadi-clad crowd demanding speeches in Hindustani. The enthusiasm of the people outside struck him as mob hysteria. There was as much difference between him and the Indian masses as between Savile Row and Bond Street and the Indian village with its mud huts. He suggested once privately that only matriculates should be taken into the Congress. I do not know if he was serious in making this remarkable suggestion, but it was in harmony with his general outlook. So he drifted away from the Congress and became a rather solitary figure in Indian politics. Later, unhappily, the old ambassador of Unity associated himself with the most reactionary elements in Muslim communalism." The history of the freedom struggle is replete with such sub-plots of individual animosities and attitudes. And all those individuals in the vanguard of that struggle were not Mahatmas; for most of them perhaps, partition of the land alone ensured absolute power. They were politicians too, no matter whether the party was called the Indian National Congress or the Muslim League. Only Gandhi saw the void in the heart of Independence. He even skipped the party. Moral was the only adjective worthy of his definition of freedom.

Today, it's all about the partition of the mind, and it gets starker as the argument with the past centres more and more on one-dimensional saints and sinners. Our search for the men who divided India takes special care to avoid the routes preferred by politicians who collect their wares from the grey markets of history. It is a journey, as the following pages show, that makes the present a lot more comprehensible—and tolerable. ■